

Sinoconodon

SIGH-no-CON-oh-don



- **When** 200 million years ago (Late Triassic)
- **Fossil location** China
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 12 in (30 cm)
- **Diet** Omnivorous

Sinoconodon is one of the earliest known mammals. Its ear bones show that it was a mammal, but like a reptile it had teeth that were continuously replaced throughout life. It was about the size of a squirrel and had a slim snout but a strong jaw joint and chin, suggesting a powerful bite—perhaps it preyed on large insects or small reptiles.



▲ **HAIRY CREATURE** *Fur evolved as a means of keeping the body warm. It allowed early mammals to stay active at night when cold-blooded reptiles had to rest.*

Megazostrodon

MEG-ah-ZO-stroh-don



- **When** 190 million years ago (Early Jurassic)
- **Fossil location** S. Africa
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 4 in (10 cm)
- **Diet** Insects

Megazostrodon was built like a shrew, with a slender body and a long snout and tail. Its skeleton was not specialized for any particular lifestyle, but it probably climbed, burrowed, and ran, much like modern rats and shrews. Studies of its braincase indicate it had a relatively large



brain and the well-developed hearing and smell of a nocturnal animal (an animal that's active by night). Its teeth suggest a diet of insects. It probably hunted for insects and other small animals at night and hid from danger during daylight hours.

Morganucodon

MORE-gan-oo-CODE-on

- **When** 210–180 million years ago (Late Triassic to Early Jurassic)
- **Fossil location** Wales, China, USA
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 4 in (9 cm)
- **Diet** Insects

Morganucodon was discovered in Wales, where thousands of fossilized teeth and broken bones were found in a quarry. Later, similar fossils were found as far apart as China, South Africa, and North America, suggesting this creature was common and widespread at the



time of the dinosaurs. A tiny, shrewlike animal, it had short legs and a short tail. It probably laid eggs as reptiles do, and its jaw showed a mixture of mammalian and reptilian features.

Eomaia

EE-oh-MY-ah

- **When** 125 million years ago (Early Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** China
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 8 in (20 cm)
- **Diet** Insects and other small animals

Only one fossil of *Eomaia* exists but it is beautifully preserved and shows a thick coat of fur as well as features typical of a good climber, such as a very long tail. Studies of the bones show *Eomaia* was more closely related to mammals that give birth to well-developed babies than to egg-layers or marsupials.



Zalambdalestes

ZAH-lam-da-LESS-tease



- **When** 80–70 million years ago (Late Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** Mongolia
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 8 in (20 cm)
- **Diet** Insects

This creature was one of the earliest “placental mammals” (mammals that give birth to well-developed babies). It had a very long, narrow snout and teeth that grew continuously throughout its life, as those of rodents do. Its hindlimbs were longer than its forelimbs, allowing it to hop like a jerboa. Its pointed teeth suggest a diet of insects and maybe seeds.

